same city. Despite all the extra security, there were fans everywhere waiting to catch a glimpse of the team and wish us well. It was a kind of passion we had not seen before.

On the way from the airport, the police didn't want to take any chances and escorted our bus to the hotel. On the way, I met Anjali on Mumbai's Sea Link, the bridge that is now a landmark and has made commuting in the city much easier. (Before, there were times when I was playing a first-class match in Mumbai and I would choose to stay the night at the CCI rather than go to my own home, as it could take an hour and thirty minutes to drive there, which is not what you want after a long day in the field!) I had already informed the security personnel on the team bus that Anjali would be waiting for me and that I would be moving from the team bus to my car. Driving my own car didn't make the journey to the hotel any quicker, because I was keeping the team bus in my sight. There were people everywhere and I don't think I went above 40 kph. In fact I remember saying to Anjali that my car must think someone else is driving it at that speed.

While driving to the hotel I was also trying to take stock of the situation. It was hard to imagine I was going to play the World Cup final in front of my home crowd. I couldn't help thinking back to March 2007 when I had returned to Mumbai after a disastrous World Cup campaign. That year, in hindsight, was a real nightmare. However, 2011 felt different, because we were gradually writing a national fairy tale. I told Anjali that this time there was no turning back.

We had played Sri Lanka a number of times in the recent past, in 2010 and 2011, and knew exactly what to expect from them in the final. They were a good side but we were confident of beating them. There was no need for a long team talk. We did meet for a team dinner, but after barely five minutes of cricket discussion, Mike Horn took over. All through the final week, Mike talked to us about his experiences. While for most of us there is always another day, for Mike it was often a matter of life and death. One mistake and it could all be over. The stories of how he coped with extreme pressure during his adventures – such as circumnavigating the globe at the Equator without motorized transport or walking to the North Pole during the dark season – definitely helped us deal with our own concerns on the eve of the World Cup final. They put our situation into perspective, reminding us that we were not the worst off in the world.